Rage: four guests bringing the children home

Story revision for the captain, 10 October 2026. Rage is the chosen ending. This replaces the sitting and first four excursions; it leaves the finale to `hw-rage-stakes`. Names and dates inherited from Rage remain that design's proposals.

One page: the four changes

1. One group does each child's work

Each room asks four people to finish one interrupted act: recover the courier's message, answer the lookout's warning, hear the child behind the wall, complete the youngest child's lesson. A child's name gives you a connection, not a private puzzle.

The answers stay: the hearth drop; BLACK, ONE, BLACK; the third peg; names paired with work in birth order. The final actions change wherever the old roles could collapse into one solver. All four must sustain the hearth opening, watch and signal, listening gap, or recitation board. Everyone then releases their work and hears the child. These proposed interactions need rehearsal. Shared work and protected speech apply S5, S6 and S7.

2. Bring the objects home before wearing them

You enter empty-handed. The sitting gives you a seat, a name and a rule.

The kitchen yields the satchel and gauntlets. The window yields the marked slate and veil. The cupboard yields the book and ear coverings. The nursery yields the board, ribbon, chalk and blank writing slate. Each object waits beside its relic at the table. Its first use comes at the turn.

The objects mean particular children before becoming curses. This replaces the handoff's early handout as requested, while preserving self-applied restrictions. S3, S4 and S28 support objects that accumulate meaning.

3. Encounter someone in every room

Deliverance's shadow braces the kitchen door. At Waitstill's window, he appears outside on his earlier journey home: the courier she tried to protect. Mindwell crouches beyond the cupboard boards. Remember has been under the bed since you entered.

Each presence occupies a definite place and changes the work. Existing voices combine with shadows and still figures; no additional live actor is required. Seeing the same boy in two rooms joins the story. S16 and S18 inform this staging, without proving an illusion will work in this house.

4. Every departure pursues the mother's remaining hope

“Did Deliverance come home?” sends you to the kitchen. He did, but his message never left the drop. “Did Waitstill see them reach the boat?” sends you to the window. Her warning kept the boat away. “Did Mindwell hear them leave by the woods?” sends you under the stair. She heard them inside as fire came. “Did Remember hear them called out?” sends you to the nursery. Her words place all four inside as the heat reaches her.

Each return takes something from the mother: the courier's escape, the boat, the woods, then the last child's answer. Keep her tenderness while hope shrinks. The fourth relic still breaks her. Each next room answers an earned question, following S1, S2, S8 and S23.

The sitting

You arrive carrying nothing from the game. At the door, Tamari is herself. She describes the dark and sound, the later gloves, seated blindfold, ear coverings and silence, and asks who can take each part. You may remove anything; “Cut” or “stop” ends the effects and “Less” reduces them. Safety speech remains available to everyone. No one tries on the curse objects here.

Inside, the lantern lights four names and four empty outlines. No gauntlets wait at your chair. No one gives you something to keep for later.

The medium knows only that the house burned, the magistrate's wife was taken away, and the woman still calls for her children. People say the children reached the Landing. Nobody brought their mother an answer. She does not recite the old opening's claim that all five died in the fire.

“You are here to find what became of them. She cannot leave this table. Bring back what they left, put it where they sat, and tell her what you found together. Through their things, your words can reach her.”

She gives each of you a child's name by pointing to the places. “You will find something to bring for each of you, too. Leave it beside their place. When all four are home and I say ‘Take their places’: Deliverance covers the hands; Waitstill, the eyes; Mindwell, the ears. Remember ties the ribbon and writes instead of speaking. Until then, keep your hands and senses free.”

That is the curse rule, said once. A child's name spoken in a room is not its trigger. The medium's ordinary directions cannot accidentally activate it.

The medium asks all four to lay a hand beside their empty place. “Once for yes. Twice for no.” The knock and lantern answer together. She asks whether the mother can hear the people at her table. One knock.

Then the mother speaks. “My children had a way out. Deliverance? Did he come home? I left the directions in his satchel. By the kitchen door.”

A guest can answer or ask a question. The medium receives it; she does not require a chalkboard performance before the story can start. “We can look.” She turns to all four. “Find whether he came home. Bring his satchel.”

You leave together with the medium. A woman asked you for something she cannot find out herself.

Design changes: Rage §§2 and 3 lose the death-spoiling folklore, starting equipment and arbitrary name-selection exercise. §3 retains the consent assignment, common contact, visible and audible replies, shared objective and departure. §4's commands remain ordinary directions; reserve “Take their places” for the fourth return. The mother's contact stays at the hub; room hints come from the medium reading the room, not from an omniscient mother watching offstage.

Backstory boundary, after the captain's later voice steer: the sibling now owns a replacement for design §2. The performed scenes here retain the earlier evening route as a readable proposal; they do not approve its account of the morning. Each room's dependency line below identifies the content to replace. The shared actions, objects, located ghosts and chain of questions do not require Tillery's identity, a particular departure hour or the location of the father's bargain. The intercepted-courier sketch would also change the evening route; its linked changes are identified at the window.

Deliverance: open the place where he left the message

The lead-in and the shared work

The mother's question follows you into the kitchen: did her courier come home?

His satchel hangs by the door. His cap is on the hearth shelf. A paper across the door says the Crown sealed the house after the fire. That later seal is aftermath; it cannot, by itself, prove that a boy failed to escape the previous night.

Something dark stands against the door. At first it could be a coat. Then the shoulder shifts against the bar. The cap-shaped shadow has empty hands.

Deliverance opens the folded route note in the satchel, starting at the little arrow. The others find the named irons, kettle and brick while the note opens. The mother told her son to put what he carried in the drop and run for the Landing.

The drop needs four. One of you pulls the low iron; another pulls the kettle's iron. Each iron takes both hands to keep its two grips drawn; letting either grip return closes that side of the drop. Deliverance holds the hanging kettle clear with both hands while calling the directions just read. The fourth can now reach the brick. Neither iron can be released, and the kettle must stay clear, while the brick opens. These are four parts of one awkward household hiding place, not four separate riddles.

The brick gives. Everyone can let go. A folded paper lies inside with gauntlets wrapped around it. The red wax bears JA. The boy at the door stops pushing. His voice comes from beside the bar: “If I cannot bring it, take it to Mother.” Then the shadow is still again.

He carried something home. He left it exactly where she told him. You have just done together what he could not finish alone.

The ghost and the things you carry

Deliverance is inside, at the barred door. A fixed child-shaped silhouette and a shifting shadow give the shoulder its small movement; a localized recorded voice supplies the line. No performer stands behind the door and nobody must open it. The kitchen needs this added presence; the old design had no child cue here.

The gauntlets protect the paper in the hiding place. Deliverance lifts them barehanded. The medium looks at the seal. “Bring it as you found it. She may know whose seal that is.” That is a request to show evidence intact, not a magic prohibition. If a guest opens it early, its text remains true and the medium acknowledges it; the report does not depend on suppressing a discovery.

The satchel, containing the sealed paper and route note, is the relic. The gauntlets travel beside it. They are not worn or used to solve the hearth.

The return and the next door

You set the satchel in its outline and the gauntlets beside it. The first candle lights. The medium allows the group its plain report: he came home; he used the drop; you saw him holding the door.

“He came home. Good boy.” Constance recognizes the wax. “Josiah's seal. What did he send you?” Then she reaches for the part she can still bear. “But you left the drop. You ran for the Landing.”

It is hope, not a new fact supplied by the recording. The medium can acknowledge a guest who says the boy is dead: “You saw him still at the door. She is trying to find where he could have gone.” She does not pretend the remark was inaudible.

“Waitstill could see that road. Ask her. Did she see him get to the boat?”

You leave the satchel and gauntlets with the mother. The window can answer a question the kitchen could not.

What changes in the design

- §5.1: keep arrow-first unfolding, the two irons, brick and sealed paper. Give each iron two returning grips and make the kettle an independently held obstruction; change the route note's “It takes three” to “Both irons held; kettle clear; then the brick.” The original reader could become unnecessary; this makes all four positions necessary. The grips and kettle are light props; the cooperation must not depend on strength.
- §5.1: place the gauntlets around the recovered paper; add the door shadow and short voice. Remove the medium's unsupported deduction that an after-fire seal proves no escape.

- §§5.1 and 5.5: the group reports the visible fact before the mother responds. She recognizes the seal now. Her unanswered question about its contents stays available to the finale; she does not forget seeing it.

Backstory dependency: the paper's sender, protection claim and arrival in the hearth belong to the sibling; this version assumes Deliverance reached home, so an interception before arrival requires a different trace in the drop and a different kitchen apparition, not an unexplained transfer of his papers.

Waitstill: keep the lookout's watch together

The lead-in and the shared work

The mother wants to know whether Deliverance reached the boat. You go to the window that overlooked his way home.

A spyglass, a slate of marks, a map and a signal lantern wait there. Beneath the window, Waitstill says, “He came along the Landing road. Before I showed the black.” The words place what follows earlier than the kitchen scene.

Beyond the glass stands the same boy, cap low, satchel at his side. He is looking toward the house. You have seen what awaited him inside; now you occupy the lookout's place while he comes home.

Waitstill's guest learns the key in the spyglass. Across the room, a friend reads the last marks on the slate; the others follow the road on the map and read the standing orders. Red coats on the Landing road, then at the house. The answer is still BLACK, ONE, BLACK. You are showing the warning that kept the boat away.

To send it while keeping watch takes all four. One person holds the window shutter ajar with both hands, at its edge away from the glass, so Waitstill can keep looking through it. Another holds the signal hood open with both hands toward the road, hiding the lamp from the side. A third works the lantern's sliding shutter. Waitstill stays at the glass to see the boy's reply. The supporting shutters return when released; the glass and lamp are separate stations. The observers cannot set them and walk away.

“Black.” The lantern closes. “One.” It opens. Through the glass, the boy lifts an empty hand. Only Waitstill can see that small reply through the lookout slit. Waitstill calls for the last black. The lantern closes, and the boy disappears toward the house.

There is no race to catch a fleeting signal. He holds his reply until it is answered. The signal has one shared completion, visible as the house on the map lights and the lamp settles dark. Now all four let go and listen.

“Red coats. Landing road. They're at the gate. Deliverance, bar the door. Tell Mother what I saw.”

The kitchen's braced shoulder has become the end of a warning you helped send.

The ghost and the things you carry

The visible ghost is Deliverance outside the window, returning before the scene in the kitchen. Use a figure or shadow beyond the glass; the spyglass reveals the raised hand as well as retaining its readable key. The old glass blocked all views beyond its key card, so this needs an explicit optical change. The captain cues the reply after the held light; no exterior actor or actual outdoor guest route is required.

A folded black veil rests below the lantern. It reads as the lookout's dark covering, kept to hide a glint, rather than a mourning costume supplied before anyone has died. It stays folded during this scene; the signal hood is a separate fixed part of the lantern. Nobody uses the future blindfold to solve the puzzle.

You lift the marked slate and take the folded veil with it. Waitstill has learned the whole symbol key, including Father and the bells. Everyone has helped interpret and send its last warning.

The return and the next door

The slate goes beside the satchel. The veil lies beside Waitstill's place. Another candle lights. You tell the mother that her daughter showed the black and the boat stayed out.

“She kept them off the road.” For a moment Constance sounds proud. Then: “So no boat.”

Her first escape is gone. She finds a smaller one. “The woods. They could go behind the house. Mindwell listened under the stair. She would hear the back passage. Find what she heard.”

The map has already shown the woods. Mindwell's listening place can test this route; her name is not a new destination plucked from the air.

What changes in the design

- §5.2: keep the marks, roads, bells, key and BLACK, ONE, BLACK. Replace the optional runner with the held window shutter and signal hood; put the lantern controls apart from the spyglass. Add the boy's held reply between ONE and final BLACK; the completion cue must wait for the reply rather than accept a quick sweep of the shutter. The answer survives; the final action becomes a shared watch and signal.
- §5.2: the spyglass must allow the key and a restricted view of the reply. A large apparition is visible to the room; its small acknowledgment is visible at the glass. This is a change to the original key-only tube, not a claim that it already does both.
- §§5.2 and 5.5: add the earlier-time line, Deliverance's exterior presence and the folded veil. Let the completed action finish before Waitstill's essential speech. The return explicitly loses the boat and asks about the route already on the map.

Backstory dependency: Tillery's field, Father's six-bells departure and the soldiers' exact arrival hour are unnecessary to this room's warning; omit them from its required account until the sibling fixes them, keeping only the roads, warning and failed boat route.

The captain's sketch: I would not adopt the stopped-courier version in this draft, because leaving Deliverance and the protection outside makes the hearth paper and the fourth return's “all inside” testimony false unless the evidence changes with them.

It does give the window a strong shared purpose: four guests keep sight of a brother they cannot reach, and carry that failed contact to his mother. If the sibling chooses it, retain the glass, held shutter, hood and signal; the boy's raised paper replaces his acknowledgment, and the signal cannot get him through. The return becomes “He reached the house, but not the door; the protection never reached the children.” The next question is still whether the others used the back passage. The kitchen must then yield a trace of his uncompleted errand, with a different child's ghost there; the nursery must confirm three inside and the courier lost outside, rather than put him at the bar. Those are linked story changes, not a new signal puzzle or permission to invent how he died. The sibling must supply the evidence that establishes his fate before this version can honestly support the fourth return.

At this revision checkpoint, `hw-rage-stakes/report.md` §§2–3 still says he came home and keeps the protection paper in the satchel. It contains no treatment of the new interception sketch. I have used its existing recommendation as a finale connection, not represented it as an answer to the captain's new idea.

Mindwell: make a place where you can hear her

The lead-in and the shared work

The boat never came. Perhaps the children slipped behind the house and into the woods. The mother has sent you to the person who listened to that passage.

At the cupboard, you hear a breath close to the boards. A small dark shape crouches behind them, beneath the stair. It does not advance toward you. It seems to be listening as hard as you are.

The book, pegs, lantern and horn are here. Mindwell's guest reads the family's vowel key while a friend deciphers the last entry. The other two find the third peg and examine the bowed boards below it. The writing says the door is barred, Mindwell is at her knot, and she hears fire.

The right place is known. Hearing through it is the group task. Two of you each use both hands to ease apart the bowed boards at opposite ends of the listening gap. One holds the horn's bell against the exposed knot. The fourth, at its separate earpiece on the cupboard side, listens and tells you what is coming through. The boards will not stay open, and the horn will not sit in the opening by itself. Nobody crawls inside.

“Knocking,” the listener says. Then: “Someone asking for help with the bar.” The hands at the partition can feel how little room there was for the girl on the other side. The listener hears her breath. You have made a way to hear someone who made herself too small to be found.

The lantern flickers. The medium gathers everyone to the cupboard opening; you release the boards and horn. Mindwell's close whisper now comes through the room speaker so all four receive it: “Deliverance barred it. I'm at my knot. I wrote it down so Mother would know.” Then a little crackling. The crouched shadow stays still.

Her father is not explained here. The earlier pages of the book remain evidence the group can revisit. The immediate answer is that the sound in the passage was the children still inside, with fire coming after them.

The ghost and the things you carry

Mindwell occupies the space beyond the pine boards. A still crouching figure seen through their gap, with a localized breath and voice, makes a child present there throughout. The opening view establishes her before the puzzle; the solve brings her voice close. The shared listening beat uses the existing concealed speaker and adds a room-audible end to its recording. No live child or crawling guest is needed.

Under her stool lie black ear coverings. You first see them beside a child who could hear the house and could not shut it out. The medium draws them into view after the whisper. “Bring these with her book.”

Mindwell carries the book and the uncovered hearing protectors back. They stay off the ears. In production these are the existing cloth-dressed modern protectors, a theatrical form for the curse, not a claim about colonial equipment.

The return and the next door

The book enters its outline. The third candle lights. The ear coverings sit beside it. You tell the mother what came through the wall: the bar, the children inside, the fire.

“Small under the stair. Good girl.” Constance begins the reassurance and cannot finish it. “The soldiers wouldn't see her there.”

Then she asks the question the reassurance cannot answer. “Did she hear them leave?”

The medium answers from the group's evidence. “We heard them at the door. Then the fire.”

Constance has lost the woods. She reaches for a voice. “Remember kept what she was told. If someone called them out, she would have the words. Please. Ask her.”

The last request is smaller than the first. You go to the nursery to hear an answer, not to collect the last marked token.

What changes in the design

- §5.3: keep the vowel substitution, final entry and third peg. Make the listening reveal require two held board edges, a separately held horn bell and a listener at its earpiece. This replaces the expendable lamp-and-pegs role; it changes the horn arrangement and partition, not the cipher answer.
- §5.3: two people read while two prepare the listening place; all four then sustain the listening action. The private horn carries texture and the listener's report. Essential speech follows for everyone with hands free. This avoids treating one person's audio access as four people's comprehension.
- §§5.3 and 5.5: add Mindwell's visible crouched presence and the ear coverings. The mother asks about departure and receives an answer before she sends the group to Remember. The existing cipher's rhyme must plainly identify Mother as C for U; “Mother keeps U” alone is too ambiguous to rely on.

Backstory dependency: the officer's threat, study-floor location and morning headings belong to the sibling and are not needed for the last-entry/third-peg solve; “Deliverance barred it” must change with the person at the door if the interception version is chosen.

Remember: finish the lesson she cannot stop saying

The lead-in and the shared work

The mother has asked for the words that might still get her children out. You enter the nursery together.

There is a bed, a sampler, a hornbook and the grooved board. A small hand is already visible under the bed, beside a cheek in shadow. It has been there the whole time. You do not have to search under the furniture to find her.

“Deliverance carried,” the little voice starts. It falls quiet. This is a child waiting for the rest of a lesson.

The sampler says nothing is known until it is seen, heard, carried and said. The hornbook names each child's work. The birth years put the eldest first. Each of you takes your own name tile, finds its matching work and tells the others where it belongs. Remember's guest holds the rhyme while the group checks the order, then takes the last pair.

The grooves now hold names and work on separate returning slides. Each of you needs both hands: one holds the name home, the other holds its work beside it. You speak your lines in order while keeping all eight pieces home. Remember calls, “Whole.” The medium lowers the bar across the report you are holding together. She has supplied no answer; she receives what the four of you made.

The bar catches. Your hands can come away. Four contributions have become one report.

From under the bed, Remember says the whole lesson you completed. Then the drilled voice changes. “Mother? Father said to tell you. Whatever you hear of me, I did it for you four. He said, tell your mother.”

A breath. “Deliverance is at the door. Waitstill's at the window. Mindwell's under the stair. I'm under the bed like you said. It's hot. Will you tell her?”

No moving tiles compete with those words. All four hear them. They name the places you have visited, now together in the same fire. The father's words survive without explaining his bargain.

The ghost and the things you carry

Remember is under the bed, visible from where the group works: a still small figure, hand and part of a face in shadow, voiced by the existing under-bed speaker. There is no sudden face thrust at someone searching. The disturbing fact is that she watched the whole lesson from there.

Beside the board lies a blank writing slate. Ribbon holds a piece of chalk against its edge. These belonged with the lesson before they belonged with a curse. Remember's guest takes them without untying the ribbon or writing. The whole group helps carry the board with its bar down.

The fourth return

You sit down. Three relics and three unworn objects wait for you. Remember sets the writing slate, chalk and ribbon beside the last place. Only then does the board go into its outline. Nobody is fetching equipment when it lands.

The fourth candle lights. The medium lets the group give the mother's last answer: all four still in the house as the fire reached Remember; the youngest under her bed in the heat. If someone repeats the father's sentence, she has received it too. It need not be kept secret to remain unexplained.

The mother names each place. “The door. The window. Under the stair. Under the bed.” This time there is no next possibility. “None of you got out.”

Her children kept doing what she taught them. They never reached the place she imagined for them. Four guests have brought her that knowledge, one piece at a time.

The medium rings the bell. The mother cries out.

What changes in the design

- §5.4: keep names, jobs, birth order, fitting pairs and hinged bar. Give each groove two independent returning slides, for name and verb: eight held pieces need eight hands. The guests speak the ordered report; on their “Whole,” the medium closes the bar. This replaces optional readers and interchangeable handlers with a common four-person finish. A release must actually return its piece, or fewer guests could operate the board.
- §5.4: Remember is visible before the solve. Keep the father's exact sentence; extend her final location line to name the other three still inside. This supplies the contemporaneous link that four separate abandoned possessions could not prove.
- §§3, 5.4–5.6 and 6: move the blank slate, ribbon and chalk here. All objects are laid out before the fourth relic lands. The fourth return completes the shared testimony and recognition before the fire cue; no new lesson or equipment handout interrupts it.

Backstory dependency: the father's remembered sentence is retained evidence with its meaning reserved for the sibling; the added list of four indoor locations is conditional on the homecoming version and must become evidence of the actual four fates if the courier is intercepted outside.

The turn: what the first half hands over

Four relics occupy the table: the satchel and sealed paper, the lookout's marked slate, the ear-book and the closed recitation board. Beside them lie the gauntlets, folded veil, ear coverings, ribbon, chalk and blank writing slate. All four guests are seated and still unrestricted when the fourth relic lands.

The recognition and cry lead into the fire. When the medium says “Take their places,” Deliverance puts on the gauntlets, Waitstill lowers the veil while seated, Mindwell puts on the ear coverings, and Remember ties the loose wrist ribbon, takes the chalk and stops speaking. This is their first use. Nobody reaches into a box for an unfamiliar item. Remember's writing begins now; the other rooms have already taught the group to relay what someone else alone can perceive.

Each bearer also carries learned work: Deliverance the fold, Waitstill the whole lookout key, Mindwell the cipher, Remember the report form and the father's sentence. Those remain the existing finale's inputs. Hearing the sentence early does not explain the threat or failed bargain; opening the paper early does not change its evidence. Do not make surprise depend on either fact staying secret.

The sibling report existed at this checkpoint. Its recommendation is **Let the children finish**: the mother's demand for justice keeps calling on the children, and the guests act to get their actual words heard. This first half feeds that recommendation through four explicit errands, substituted into the existing child speeches: take it to Mother; tell her what I saw; I wrote it so she would know; will you tell her? Guests have already accepted that work by carrying the relics back. Her tender praise also establishes the troubling continuity: she values their work before she asks too much of them.

The opening now leaves what she knows about her husband to the revised backstory. In the performed version below, she recognizes his seal at the first return; its sender and contents must follow the sibling's revised paper trail. What changes at the fourth is the loss of her children's escape, not sudden recognition of a seal. The sibling owns the morning's events, her next intention, the urgent objective, the cost of failure and the outcome. No finale is designed here.

Revised guest's-eye walkthrough

The following performs the provisional homecoming version; the interception alternative and its required changes are described at the window. It is also saved as `walkthrough-first-half.md`. It follows the original walkthrough's second-person prose and section sequence, and stops at the fourth return.

Rage: the guests' first half — homecoming draft

You are four guests at a séance in Ashby House, each carrying the name of one of Constance Ashby's children. You arrive with empty hands. Their mother asks you to find what became of them. Each time you come back, you bring her something she recognizes and an answer she finds harder to bear.

Arrival

Tamari meets you before you enter. She is still herself. The game gets dark and loud. Later, one of you will wear a blindfold while seated, with a friend's hand on your arm. One will wear ear coverings, one big gloves, and one will stop speaking. Nobody is tied. Nothing is locked.

She asks which restriction each of you is comfortable taking. “Cut” or “stop” brings the lights up and stops everything. “Less” lowers the intensity. You can remove anything you wear. You can always speak to stop.

Then she becomes the medium and brings you into the living room.

The sitting

A lantern burns at the centre of the table. Four empty places bear the outlines of a satchel, a slate, a book and a board. The names beside them are Deliverance, Waitstill, Mindwell and Remember.

The medium tells you that the house burned, the magistrate's wife was taken away, and her children were said to have reached the Landing. Their mother still calls for them. Nobody brought her an answer.

“She cannot leave this table. Bring back what they left, put it where they sat, and tell her what you found together. Through their things, your words can reach her.”

She gives each of you a child's name. You will find something to bring back for yourselves too. It must wait beside the child's place.

“When all four are home and I say ‘Take their places’: Deliverance covers the hands; Waitstill, the eyes; Mindwell, the ears. Remember ties the ribbon and writes instead of speaking. Until then, keep your hands and senses free.”

Each of you lays a hand beside an empty outline. The medium explains one knock for yes and two for no; the lantern answers with the sound. She asks whether the mother can hear you. One knock.

A woman's voice answers. “My children had a way out. Deliverance? Did he come home? I left the directions in his satchel. By the kitchen door.”

“We can look,” the medium says. All four of you go with her.

Deliverance's room

The kitchen door has a Crown notice across it, dated after the fire. A satchel hangs beside it. A boy's cap rests on the hearth shelf. His shadow seems to stand against the door. Then its shoulder moves, pushing at the bar.

Deliverance opens the folded note in the satchel, beginning with its ink arrow. The others find the hearth irons and the brick behind the kettle. His mother told him to hide what he carried in the drop, then run for the Landing.

Two of you pull the irons, each keeping both grips drawn with both hands. Deliverance holds the kettle clear with both hands and calls the directions. The fourth pushes the brick. All four of you must stay in place until it gives.

Inside are gauntlets wrapped around a folded paper. Its red seal bears JA. You can let go of the hearth. The boy stops pushing at the door.

“If I cannot bring it, take it to Mother.”

The medium asks you to bring the paper as you found it; the mother may know the seal. Deliverance puts it in the satchel and carries the gauntlets without wearing them.

At the table, the satchel goes in its outline. The gauntlets lie beside it. The first candle lights. You tell Constance that her son came home and used the drop. You saw him at the door.

“He came home. Good boy. Josiah's seal. What did he send you?” She stops. “But you left the drop. You ran for the Landing.”

Then she asks about the window. Waitstill could see the road. Did she see him reach the boat?

You leave the satchel and gauntlets on the table and go to find out.

Waitstill's room

A spyglass faces the street window. There is a signal lantern, a slate of marks and a map showing the house, town road, Landing road and woods.

A girl's voice comes from beneath the window. “He came along the Landing road. Before I showed the black.”

Outside stands the boy from the kitchen, cap low and satchel at his side. He is looking toward the house. This is his way home, before he barred the door.

Waitstill learns the key through the spyglass. Another guest reads the last marks on the slate. The other two follow the road on the map and read the orders. Red coats came along the Landing road, then reached the house. The warning is black, one light, black.

One of you holds the window shutter ajar with both hands, away from the glass. Another uses both hands to hold the lamp's hood open toward the road. A third moves its sliding shutter. Waitstill stays at the glass, watching the boy. If the supporting hands let go, the sightline or the signal closes.

You close the light, then open it. Through the glass, Waitstill sees the boy lift an empty hand. He waits. Waitstill calls for the last black. The lamp closes and the boy disappears toward the house.

The house on the map lights. You let go and listen.

“Red coats. Landing road. They're at the gate. Deliverance, bar the door. Tell Mother what I saw.”

A folded black veil lies below the lantern. You take it with the slate. Nobody puts it on.

Back at the table, the slate goes in its outline, the veil beside it. Another candle lights. You tell the mother that Waitstill showed the warning. The boat stayed away.

“She kept them off the road.” Then: “So no boat.”

After a pause, Constance says they could have gone by the woods behind the house. Mindwell listened under the stair. She would have heard them use the back passage.

You leave the slate and veil and go to the cupboard.

Mindwell's room

There is a breath behind the pine boards. Through their gap you can make out a child crouching beneath the stair. She seems to be listening.

A cloth-bound book lies by the lantern. A horn hangs beside it. Pegs run above the boards.

Mindwell reads the book's vowel key while another guest deciphers the last entry. The other two find the named peg and the bowed boards beneath it. The words say Deliverance barred the door. Mindwell is at her knot, under the third peg. She hears fire.

Two of you each use both hands to ease the boards apart and hold them. A third holds the horn's bell against the exposed knot. The fourth listens at its separate earpiece, outside the gap.

“Knocking,” the listener says. Then: “Someone asking for help with the bar.” There is a breath close to the horn. You keep the opening clear together until the lantern flickers.

The medium brings all four of you to the cupboard opening. You can release the boards. The voice comes through clearly now.

“Deliverance barred it. I'm at my knot. I wrote it down so Mother would know.” Then crackling. The child stays small behind the boards.

Black ear coverings lie beneath the stool. The medium asks you to bring them with the book. Mindwell carries both back. The ear coverings remain off.

The third candle lights when the book enters its outline. You tell the mother what you heard: the children at the door, then the fire.

“Small under the stair. Good girl. The soldiers wouldn't see her there.” She pauses. “Did she hear them leave?”

“We heard them at the door,” the medium says. “Then the fire.”

“Remember kept what she was told. If someone called them out, she would have the words. Please. Ask her.”

You leave the book and ear coverings and follow the medium to the nursery.

Remember's room

A child's hand lies in the shadow under the bed. Behind it you can see part of a cheek. Remember is already there.

“Deliverance carried,” she says. Then she stops.

Above the bed, a sampler gives the family's rule: nothing is known until it is seen, heard, carried and said. On the table are a hornbook, a board with four grooves, and the name and word tiles.

Each of you takes your name. The hornbook tells you the matching work; the sampler gives the birth order. You check the pairs and places together.

Each name and each word slides home but returns when released. You each hold your name with one hand and its work with the other. Keeping all eight pieces home, you say the four lines in order. Remember calls, “Whole.” The medium lowers the bar across the report you are holding. It lies flat. You can let go.

The child under the bed recites the complete lesson. “Deliverance carried. Waitstill saw. Mindwell heard. Remember said.”

Then her voice changes. “Mother? Father said to tell you. Whatever you hear of me, I did it for you four. He said, tell your mother.”

“Deliverance is at the door. Waitstill's at the window. Mindwell's under the stair. I'm under the bed like you said. It's hot. Will you tell her?”

Beside the board is a blank writing slate, with chalk held against its edge by a ribbon. Remember takes them without untying the ribbon. Together you carry the closed board back.

The satchel, lookout's slate and book wait at the table. Their objects lie beside them. You all sit. Remember puts the writing slate, chalk and ribbon within reach, then places the board in the last outline.

The fourth candle lights. You give the mother the last answer. All four were still inside as the fire reached Remember. Remember was under her bed in the heat.

“The door,” Constance says. “The window. Under the stair. Under the bed.”

There is no next place to look.

“None of you got out.”

The medium rings the bell. The mother's cry begins.

Where this strains the plan

- Handoff: the captain's room-earned objects supersede §8's opening handout; visible ghosts allow guests to infer death early, while the fourth return remains the mother's recognition.
- Thirty-minute run: the new joint actions and object collection need rehearsal; removed tutorials and substituted speech may offset them, but the sibling's longer finale leaves the overall ceiling unverified.
- Build: the four shared gates, seeing through the spyglass, and four located apparitions exceed the old room builds; the cramped listening place must let all four work from the cupboard and its doorway.

Captain's calls

These five choices belong on the existing `halloween-2026-review`. The recommendations make this draft readable now; none records an answer from the captain. Rage, the repeated returns, room-earned objects and four required guests are instructions, not questions reopened here. The sibling owns the backstory, finale and mother's knowledge choice; the opening now leaves that knowledge unspecified.

Call	Options	Recommended default
C1 — Who appears at the window	Deliverance on the earlier approach; Deliverance intercepted with the papers; or Waitstill at her own post	Keep Deliverance as the cross-room connection. The performed homecoming is provisional; adopt interception only with the sibling's connected paper trail and fourth-return evidence, as described at the window.
C2 — How much of the children we see	A plainly visible still figure; a partial figure or shadow; a detailed projection	Partial figures and shadows. Everyone should locate the child; nobody needs a convincing animated face.
C3 — The mother's tone before she breaks	Tender and increasingly desperate; or commanding and increasingly angry	Tender, then desperate. Keep “Good boy” and “Good girl”; the requests shorten as each escape fails.
C4 — What the curse objects represent	Literal surviving household things; or recognizable theatrical objects attached to the children's traces	Theatrical objects, with the gauntlets and slate most literal. Do not invent colonial hearing protectors or an extra owner for the veil.
C5 — Whether the children address these guests	Direct brief requests; or entirely overheard remnants of the past	Direct requests after the shared work. They make carrying the objects an accepted errand and feed the sibling's recommendation.

Evidence and limits

I read the requested sources in order, recovering only passages clipped by tool output. Story authority came from the full handoff; comparison came from the full guest walkthrough; design changes use Rage §§1–6 only; craft references use the supplied research's 28-source catalogue and Rage application; mechanics constraints use synthesis §0 only. I did not independently reopen the research's external articles. S-numbers below and above refer to that supplied research.

Source	Relevant location and use
Story handoff	Lines 29, 54, 107, 130, 187 and 229: family, failed bargain, mother's discovery, fire, curse continuity and relic trigger. The father is forced to participate in her execution; the design's weaker “witness” history is not adopted.
Walkthrough read by the captain	Lines 13, 29, 51, 71, 91 and 111: sitting, four room scenes and fire. The separate revised walkthrough follows its voice and order.

Source	Relevant location and use
Rage design	Lines 84, 175, 231, 303, 367, 431, 450 and 465: opening, original gates, returns, accumulated evidence and turn. Each room above names its exact deviations.
Storytelling research	Lines 5 and 446: ten principles and Rage application. S1/S8 support motivated action; S2/S3 the changing hub; S4/S28 evidence; S5 shared work; S6/S7 attention; S10/S11 responsive acknowledgment; S16/S18 located encounters; S23 cumulative returns.
Synthesis	Line 5, §0a rules 2, 5, 8, 10 and 23; §0b rules 2–4: four necessary participants, visible results, a clear convention, rehearsal through play and protected speech.
Sibling stakes recommendation	§§1–3: Let the children finish, the father's seal understood early, and the four requests that feed the final errand. Read when drafting the turn; alternate finales remain that report's work.

This is a story proposal, not a built or played room. A shared physical gate can still become dull if three guests only hold things while one thinks; the draft pairs each held action with prior joint interpretation and an encounter everyone receives. Rehearsal must check that all four can explain their contribution and the mother's next question. It must also try whether a guest can bypass a supposed four-person finish. No timing or comprehension result is claimed. Nothing here is ready to ship as game code.

The HTML uses the existing Rage page's cream background, Georgia body, system headings and parchment navigation, copied from its first forty lines. Only this report's navigation is added. The rendering script and both Markdown files accompany the report; existing reports, pages, notes, storyboard and simulation stay unchanged.

Artifact verification used `uv venv .venv` as requested; it found an existing environment, which I retained. `uv pip install --python .venv/bin/python markdown` returned “Checked 1 package.” Running `.venv/bin/python /media/griswald/wd-black-2tb/personal/firstmate/data/hw-rage-rooms/render.py` produced the static HTML. The accompanying render.py resolves the local source links and supplies print styling. No pandoc or Lavish command ran.

`chrome-devtools-axi open file:///media/griswald/wd-black-2tb/personal/firstmate/.lavish/hw-rage-rooms/index.html` loaded the report. Browser inspection found ten main sections, no broken navigation anchors, no horizontal overflow, the expected cream background and Georgia body type. A screenshot was inspected. The revised print copy is thirteen pages, including the walkthrough, with the four-change overview on page one; this was checked with the installed WeasyPrint renderer. Browser pagination may vary. The task's reading tab was closed after inspection.

`git diff --stat` remained empty; only task scratch files were untracked. The existing review's reason was extended with C1–C5 and this report's location, preserving its prior questions. No new review task, captain answer, push or PR was created. The shared completion result is recorded below.

Completion command: `FM_HOME=/media/griswald/wd-black-2tb/personal/firstmate /media/griswald/wd-black-2tb/personal/firstmate/bin/fm-captain-hold.sh complete hw-rage-rooms halloween-2026-review`. Result: `complete: hw-rage-rooms captain-call inventory reviewed (halloween-2026-review)`. The report tab was closed and the original Rage reading page restored. The review remains open for the captain's actual choices. Inbox instruction 001 subsequently reopened this report for the backstory dependency pass; its completion is recorded below.

Inbox 001 revision: removed the opening's assumption about the mother's knowledge of her husband and the required arrival-hour detail; added four room-specific backstory dependency lines; assessed the intercepted-courier sketch and identified the connected replacements it needs. The standalone walkthrough is labeled the homecoming draft. The sibling report had no sketch-specific revision at this checkpoint. C1 was updated on the existing review without changing the other calls. The new HTML check found all four dependency lines, no broken navigation and no overflow; its tab was closed. The completion command was rerun successfully: `complete: hw-rage-rooms captain-call inventory reviewed (halloween-2026-review)`.